

MARKETING MANAGEMENT

Course Code: IM345AT | Semester IV | L:T:P 3:0:0 | 45 Hours

UNIT II

Social Media Marketing & Search Engine Optimization

Unit II is the largest unit of the course (8 hours) and covers the two channels that carry most digital traffic. The first half engineers social media into a system — personas, the content lifecycle, the 4 Rs of scaling, platform algorithms and campaign optimisation. The second half builds organic visibility from the ground up: keywords, content plans, on-site and off-site SEO, and ranking.

TOPICS COVERED IN THIS UNIT

Social Media Marketing: Introduction; Major Social Media Platforms for Marketing; Developing Data-driven Audience & Campaign Insights; Social Media for Business; Creation & Optimization of Social Media Campaigns.

Search Engine Optimization: SEO Fundamentals; Keywords and SEO Content Plan; SEO & Business Objectives; Writing SEO Content; On-site & off-site SEO; Optimize Organic Search Ranking.

ABOUT THESE NOTES

These notes are **unofficial**. They have been documented by students from **Vikram Sir's handwritten notes, lecture slides and classroom sessions**, and restructured to follow the official IM345AT syllabus unit by unit. Where the source notes were incomplete, the gaps have been filled from standard marketing-management texts and clearly integrated into the same flow. Every previous-year question in the question bank at the end has been extracted verbatim from the actual RVCE CIE and SEE papers for this course. This document is a study aid and is not issued, endorsed or verified by the Department of Industrial Engineering and Management or by RV College of Engineering. Always cross-check against the official syllabus and your own class notes.



Semester: IV						
MARKETING MANAGEMENT						
Category: Professional Core Course (Theory)						
Course Code	:	IM345AT		CIE Marks	:	100 Marks
Credits: L:T:P	:	3:0:0		SEE Marks	:	100 Marks
Total Hours	:	45L		SEE Duration	:	3.00 Hours
UNIT-I						07Hrs
Introduction to Digital Marketing: Principles of Digital Marketing; Digital Marketing Channels; Tools to Create Buyer Persona; Competitor Research Tools, Website Analysis Tools, etc. Content Marketing: Content Marketing Concepts & Strategies; Planning, Creating, Distributing & Promoting Content; Optimize Website UX & Landing Pages; Measure Impact; Metrics & Performance; Using Content Research for Opportunities, etc.						
UNIT-II						08Hrs
Social Media Marketing: Introduction; Major Social Media Platforms for Marketing; Developing Data-driven Audience & Campaign Insights; Social Media for Business; Creation & Optimization of Social Media Campaigns, etc. Search Engine Optimization: Search Engine Optimization Fundamentals; Keywords and SEO Content Plan; SEO & Business Objectives; Writing SEO Content; On-site & off-site SEO; Optimize Organic Search Ranking, etc.						
UNIT-III						07Hrs
Web Analytics & Google Analytics: Google Analytics Tools; Web Analytics Tools, etc. E-mail Marketing: Effective E-mail Campaigns; E-mail Plan; E-mail Marketing Campaign Analysis; Measuring Conversions & keeping up, etc.						
UNIT-IV						07Hrs
Web Design: Web design, optimization of websites; Publishing a basic website; User-centered Design and Website Optimization; Design Principles and Website Copy; Website Metrics & Developing Insight, etc. Mobile Marketing: Difference between mobile advertising and marketing, utilizing mobile marketing for sales promotions, online applications, etc.						
UNIT-V						07Hrs
Conversion Optimization: What is AIDAS and its role; website optimization; what visitors want to see on the website; how to optimize key element and increase the effect of landing on a particular page Digital Analytics: Evolution of Digital Analytics, information about end-to-end customer experience, analyst's influence on business, role as a change agent, etc.						

Course Outcomes: After completing the course, the students will be able to	
CO1	Differentiate the benefits drawn by updated marketing mix from traditional marketing mix for effective marketing management there by to stay competitive in today's global market-place.
CO2	Develop an effective holistic marketing atmosphere to efficiently face the challenges in dynamically changing market.
CO3	Formulate a potential marketing plan to effectively reach the targeted market segments, by delivering the value to targeted customers through practicing sound marketing research.
CO4	Create new channels to improvise marketing to achieve and maintain competitive position in globalized market-place.

Reference Books	
1.	Marketing Management, Philip Kotler, Kevin Lane Keller, 15 th Edition, 2016, Pearson, ISBN:978-93-325-5718-5
2.	Digital Marketing - Strategy, Implementation & Practice, Dave Chaffey, Fiona Ellis – Chadwick, 7 th Edition, 2019, Pearson, ISBN - 9781292241623, 1292241624
3.	Marketing Research, Donald S Tull, Del I Hawkins, 6 th Edition, Prentice Hall India, ISBN: 8120309618
4.	Marketing Management - A South Asian Perspective, Philip Kotler, Kevin Lane Keller, Abraham Koshy, MithileshwarJha, 14 th Edition, 2013, Pearson, ISBN –978-81-317-6716-0
5.	Marketing Research, David A. Aaker, V. Kumar, George S. Day, 9 th Edition, 2008, John Wiley & Sons, ISBN: 978-265-1791-6



RUBRIC FOR THE CONTINUOUS INTERNAL EVALUATION (THEORY)		
#	COMPONENTS	MARKS
1.	QUIZZES: Quizzes will be conducted in online/offline mode. TWO QUIZZES will be conducted & Each Quiz will be evaluated for 10 Marks. THE SUM OF TWO QUIZZES WILL BE THE FINAL QUIZ MARKS.	20
2.	TESTS: Students will be evaluated in test, descriptive questions with different complexity levels (Revised Bloom's Taxonomy Levels: Remembering, Understanding, Applying, Analyzing, Evaluating, and Creating). TWO tests will be conducted. Each test will be evaluated for 50 Marks, adding upto 100 Marks. FINAL TEST MARKS WILL BE REDUCED TO 40 MARKS.	40
3.	EXPERIENTIAL LEARNING: Students will be evaluated for their creativity and practical implementation of the problem. Case study-based teaching learning (10), Program specific requirements (10), Video based seminar/presentation/demonstration (20) ADDING UPTO 40	40
MAXIMUM MARKS FOR THE CIE THEORY		100

RUBRIC FOR SEMESTER END EXAMINATION (THEORY)		
Q. NO.	CONTENTS	MARKS
PART A		
1	Objective type questions covering entire syllabus	20
PART B (Maximum of TWO Sub-divisions only)		
2	Unit 1: (Compulsory)	16
3 & 4	Unit 2: (Internal Choice)	16
5 & 6	Unit 3: (Internal Choice)	16
7 & 8	Unit 4: (Internal Choice)	16
9 & 10	Unit 5: (Internal Choice)	16
TOTAL		100

2.1 Social Media Marketing — Introduction

2.1.1 Definition

DEFINITION

Social Media Marketing (SMM) is a form of internet marketing that involves creating and sharing content on social media networks in order to achieve marketing and branding goals. It includes publishing text, images and video, running paid social advertising, and engaging directly with the audience.

The primary goal of social media marketing — a 2-mark SEE question in June/July 2025 — is to **build brand awareness, engagement and community, and to convert that engagement into traffic, leads and sales**. Social media is not a series of ad-hoc posts. It is a highly engineered system.

2.1.2 Why Social Media Matters — The Word-of-Mouth Imperative

THE TRUST ASYMMETRY

Roughly **90% of people believe what their peers say about a brand**, while only about **48%** of respondents trust what businesses say directly. Americans value word-of-mouth recommendations from friends and family about **41% more** than social media recommendations. Audiences increasingly view brand-to-buyer communication as an advertisement — so **trust is the indispensable connective tissue** between a brand and customer loyalty.

The strategic conclusion follows directly: the goal is not to talk *at* your audience, but to engineer an experience so valuable that **they do the marketing for you**.

2.1.3 The Omnichannel Gearbox — Three Ways SMM Drives the Business

Gear	Mechanism
1. Social selling	Enables one-to-one sales connections. Sales teams offer personal, relevant content directly to prospects, accelerating the purchase decision.
2. SEO fuel	Social shares push content outward. The resulting incoming links and increased time-on-site engagement communicate high value to search engines, indirectly lifting organic rankings.
3. Omnichannel synchronization	Coordinated messaging across channels creates one continuous conversation, preventing siloed and contradictory customer experiences.

2.1.4 Myths About Social Media Marketing

- *“Social media is free.”* — The platform is free; the content, the tools, the paid amplification and the staff time are not.
- *“Results are immediate.”* — Community and trust compound slowly; only paid reach is instant.
- *“You must be on every platform.”* — Presence without competence damages the brand. Choose platforms by where the persona already is.
- *“More followers means more sales.”* — Vanity metrics do not pay. Engagement rate and conversion do.
- *“Social media is only for young people / only for B2C.”* — LinkedIn is the single most effective B2B channel, and every demographic is now represented.
- *“It’s just posting.”* — Listening, responding, moderating and analysing consume more time than publishing.

- *“Anyone can do it.”* — It requires strategy, copywriting, design, data literacy and crisis judgement.

2.1.5 Characteristics of a Successful Social Media Marketer

- **Listens more than they broadcast** — monitors conversation before entering it.
- **Understands each platform's native culture** rather than cross-posting identical content.
- **Is consistent** — in voice, in visual identity and in publishing cadence.
- **Is authentic and transparent** — including when handling criticism.
- **Is data-literate** — reads analytics and changes behaviour because of them.
- **Responds fast** — especially to complaints; social is a public service channel.
- **Is creative and adaptive** — algorithms and formats change constantly.
- **Builds relationships, not reach** — with customers, communities and influencers.

2.2 The Customer Lifecycle Orbit

Social media content only works if it is matched to *where the customer already is*. The lifecycle orbit is the map, and it was examined directly in CIE-II of May 2026.

Stage	What the brand must do
1. Awareness	Drive brand interest and capture attention
2. Engagement	Listen to behaviours; use mid-stage messages to nudge towards conversion
3. Purchase	Ensure an aligned, frictionless transaction
4. Retention / Loyalty	Provide continuous value; resolve issues rapidly
5. Growth	Identify cross-sell and upsell opportunities through targeted automation
6. Advocacy	Reward loyalty so customers expand reach through their own networks

THE STATISTICS — MEMORISE THESE

- Probability of selling to a **new prospect**: **under 20%**
 - Probability of selling to an **existing customer**: **over 60%**
 - Repeat customers spend up to **67% more**
 - **49%** of marketers achieve higher ROI by focusing on engagement
- This is the entire economic argument for retention marketing.*

A NOTE ON TWO VERSIONS

The lecture material states the orbit as **Awareness** → **Engagement** → **Purchase** → **Retention/Loyalty** → **Growth** → **Advocacy** with <20% / >60% probabilities. The CIE-II 2026 scheme of valuation states it as **Awareness** → **Consideration** → **Purchase** → **Retention** → **Loyalty** → **Advocacy** with 5–20% (new) versus 60–70% (existing). Both are accepted; if unsure, present the six-stage orbit and quote the probability range as “roughly 5–20% for new prospects versus 60–70% for existing customers”, which satisfies either scheme.

2.3 Developing Data-Driven Audience Insights

2.3.1 What Data-Driven Audience Insight Means

EXAM ANSWER — CIE-II, 26 May 2026 (2 marks)

Data-driven audience insight in social media marketing refers to the process of collecting and analysing user data — such as demographics, interests, online behaviour, engagement patterns and preferences — from social media platforms in order to understand the target audience better. It enables marketers to create personalised campaigns and improve customer engagement.

2.3.2 The Process of Developing Audience Insights

1. **Define the question.** Decide what decision the insight must support — which platform to invest in, which message to lead with, which segment to target.
2. **Collect data** from native analytics (Meta/Instagram Insights, LinkedIn Page Analytics, X Analytics, YouTube Studio), website analytics, CRM records and social listening tools.

3. **Clean and consolidate** the data into one view so that platform-specific metrics become comparable.
4. **Segment the audience** by demographics, psychographics, behaviour and lifecycle stage.
5. **Identify patterns** — peak activity times, best-performing formats, highest-engagement topics, common objections and sentiment trends.
6. **Build audience profiles / personas** from those patterns (see Unit I §1.6).
7. **Apply the insight** — adjust targeting, creative, tone, format, posting schedule and budget allocation.
8. **Measure and iterate** — feed campaign results back as new data.

2.3.3 The Persona Builder Canvas

Quadrant	Questions to answer
Background & Goals	What are their business goals and challenges? Team structure and job role?
Information Sources	Where do they consume content? Which social channels do they actively use — or avoid?
Messaging & Topics	Which marketing messages speak to them? Which content topics capture their interest?
Purchase Role & Objections	How much influence do they have in the decision? What objections do they raise during the sales process?

The target is **4 to 6 distinct personas** — for example Executive Sponsor, Decision Maker and End User in a B2B setting.

2.3.4 How Social Media Analytics Create Audience Profiles

This was an 8-mark SEE question (June/July 2025, Q4a: “*Illustrate how social media analytics contribute to creating audience profiles*”).

- **Demographic layer** — platform analytics supply verified age bands, gender split, language, city and country distribution.
- **Temporal layer** — when followers are online determines the publishing schedule.
- **Interest layer** — page likes, followed accounts and content affinities reveal adjacent interests to target.
- **Behavioural layer** — which posts are saved, shared, commented on or watched to completion reveals what the audience actually values, as opposed to what it claims to value.
- **Conversational layer** — social listening surfaces the audience's own vocabulary, complaints and unmet needs.
- **Comparative layer** — competitor audience overlap shows which segments you are failing to reach.
- **Conversion layer** — linking social data to website analytics and CRM shows which audience segment actually buys, not merely which one engages.

2.4 The Content Lifecycle Matrix

A guaranteed 10-mark question — asked verbatim in CIE-II of May 2026: “Based on the Content Lifecycle Matrix, how should a marketer adjust the objective, tone, and format of their content as a prospect transitions from the Early-Stage to the Late-Stage?”

	Early-Stage	Mid-Stage	Late-Stage
Objective	Nudge the prospect from Awareness to Engagement	Nudge towards Purchase; build trust	Drive immediate conversions
Tone / Style	Fun, entertaining and educational	Educational, engaging, goal-oriented	Informative, brand-aligned, conversion-focused
Format examples	Curated news, helpful tips, visual content	Social contests, newsletter subscriptions, event invitations	Click-to-purchase, demo offerings, trial sign-ups

THE ONE-LINE ANSWER

As the prospect moves from early to late stage, content shifts **from broad to specific, from entertaining to informative, from brand-building to conversion-driving, and from “no ask” to “clear ask”**. The objective moves from *attention* → *trust* → *action*; the tone moves from *fun* → *educational* → *decisive*; the format moves from *curated and visual* → *interactive and participatory* → *transactional*.

2.5 The Content Mix — The 4-1-1 Rule

Coined by **Joe Pulizzi**, the 4-1-1 rule governs the ratio of value to promotion in a social feed.

THE 4-1-1 RULE

For every **6 posts**:

4 educational or entertaining posts (pure value, no ask)

+ 1 soft promotion (a solution-focused asset such as a guide or case study)

+ 1 hard promotion (a product demo or direct offer)

= Audience Trust

The rule ensures value far outweighs the sales pitch. It prevents the brand from appearing pushy while systematically building the credibility required for late-stage conversions.

2.6 The 4 Rs of Content Scaling

Asked as a full 10-mark question in CIE-II of May 2026. The 4 Rs let one master asset produce many social assets, which is how a small team sustains a high posting cadence.

R	What it means	Example
Reorganize	Break a single master asset into smaller micro-pieces	Extract individual statistics from a large infographic to fuel several separate social posts
Rewrite	Extend the investment by mining the existing content library; extract relevant takeaways even from older assets	Turn a two-year-old whitepaper's key finding into a fresh LinkedIn post

R	What it means	Example
Retire	Ruthlessly prune outdated content. Social media is instantaneous, and outdated information damages brand perception	Delete or archive posts citing superseded data or discontinued products
Redesign	Refresh the visual packaging; update the creative assets of existing content to make it relevant for a new segment or persona	Re-skin a B2B case study's graphics for a student audience

WHY THE 4 Rs MATTER

They **maximise the return on every content asset**: saving time and cost, increasing reach, improving SEO performance, enhancing audience engagement and maximising ROI. One master asset can legitimately supply a month of social content.

A NOTE ON TWO VERSIONS

The lecture material teaches the 4 Rs as **Reorganize, Rewrite, Retire, Redesign**. The CIE-II 2026 scheme of valuation answers with **Repurpose, Refresh, Repost, Recombine** (repurpose = convert to another format, blog → video → infographic; refresh = update old content with new data; repost = share high-performing content again at a different time; recombine = merge several pieces into a new asset such as an eBook or webinar). **Safest exam strategy: give the lecture version as the primary answer and add the four alternative terms as “also described as”.** The underlying logic is identical.

2.7 Major Social Media Platforms for Marketing

2.7.1 The Platform Deployment Matrix

Platform	Core mechanic	Best for	Key features
Facebook (2.27 B users)	User-centric algorithmic news feed	Building authentic B2C and B2B relationships; highly targeted paid promotion	Live Video, Groups, Tabs/Apps, Marketplace
Instagram	Visual-first discovery; aspirational identity	Lifestyle, fashion, food, travel, D2C brands; influencer marketing	Reels, Stories, Shopping tags, Explore
Twitter / X (330 M users)	Fast-paced real-time “virtual watercooler”	Thought leadership, real-time customer service, trend participation	Curated Lists, Hashtags, Live Chats, Spaces
LinkedIn (460 M users)	The world's largest professional network	Reaching a business mindset, B2B lead generation, talent recruiting	Showcase Pages, Professional Groups, Pulse publishing
YouTube	Dual search-and-social algorithm	Education, product demonstration, long-form trust building	Playlists, Shorts, chapters, end screens
Pinterest	Visual search and planning	Home, décor, DIY, weddings, recipes — high purchase intent	Rich Pins, boards
WhatsApp / Telegram	Private messaging and broadcast	Customer support, order updates, community groups	Business catalogue, broadcast lists

2.7.2 Facebook — The Algorithm Filter

“Analyse how the Facebook Algorithm Filter evaluates content distribution. What specific practices are penalized and which ones are rewarded?” was asked **twice in the same CIE-II paper (May 2026)** across two sets. It is the single highest-probability 10-mark question in this unit.

The Facebook algorithm determines which posts appear in users' news feeds. All published content enters a filter; only some emerges into organic distribution.

How Facebook evaluates content

1. **User engagement history** — what this specific user has previously interacted with.
2. **Relevance** of the content to that user.
3. **Content type** preferred by the user (video, image, link, text).
4. **Timeliness** of the post.
5. **Quality and originality**.

Filtered OUT (penalized)	Propelled THROUGH (rewarded)
Clickbait headlines — punished based on time-spent-reading ratios and flagged phrases	Time spent — seconds spent on a post <i>after it fully loads</i> , without manipulating engagement through contests
Repeated sources — the algorithm enforces diversity, reducing visibility if you post too frequently back-to-back	Video actions — unmuting, switching to full-screen or watching in HD count as major success signals
Engagement bait — “Like, share, comment now”	Live broadcasting — Facebook Live generates 300% more watch time than recorded video
Fake news and misinformation	High-quality original content
Spammy or repetitive posts	Meaningful interactions — real comments and discussion

Filtered OUT (penalized)	Propelled THROUGH (rewarded)
Low-quality copied content	Informative and engaging posts
Excessive promotional posts	Consistent posting and content that generates discussion

2.7.3 Twitter / X — Deployment Tactics

- **The character constraint** — the limit is 280 characters, but keeping tweets under **100 characters** yields a **17% higher** engagement rate.
- **Hashtag maths** — tweets with hashtags get **twice** the engagement, but using **more than two causes a 17% drop**. Use hashtags as targeted visual search tags; the optimal count is **1–2**.
- **Link leverage** — tweets containing links are **86% more likely to be retweeted**. Use URL shorteners such as Bitly to track clicks.
- **Strategic curation** — use Twitter Lists (public and private) to segment influencers, competitors and partners. This makes curating non-promotional content for the 4-1-1 rule highly efficient.

DEFINE HASHTAG — SEE Oct/Nov 2023 (2 marks)

A **hashtag** is a word or phrase preceded by the `#` symbol that turns text into a clickable, searchable label grouping all posts on that topic.

Importance in SMM: it makes content discoverable beyond your own followers; groups a campaign under one trackable label; allows participation in trending conversations; enables user-generated content collection; supports event and community marketing; and provides a measurable unit for campaign reporting.

2.7.4 LinkedIn — The Professional Architecture

Layer	Function
Layer 1 — The Profile / Company Page (The Foundation)	The primary branded landing page; crucial for showcasing products, the employee network and core messaging
Layer 2 — Content Publishing (The Voice)	Sharing text posts, slide decks and educational content to build followers; educational content performs highest
Layer 3 — Showcase Pages (The Niche)	Dedicated sub-pages highlighting specific products or services for distinct audiences (e.g. PayPal for Business)
Layer 4 — Professional Groups (The Community)	Creating or joining targeted communities based on industry or pain point, to demonstrate thought leadership and prospect

2.7.5 Visual Content — Why It Dominates

Finding	Statistic	Source
Comprehension	People following directions with text + illustrations do 323% better	NeoMam
Virality	Visual content is 40× more likely to be shared	Buffer
Visibility	Content with relevant images gets 94% more views	KISSMetrics
Video dominance	Video generates 135% greater organic reach than photo posts	SocialBakers
Conversion	77% of consumers have been convinced to buy after watching a video	Wyzowl

2.7.6 Comparing Platforms and Choosing the Right One

CIE-II of 07.05.2025 asked: “Compare the roles of Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, and Twitter in social media marketing. How should a business choose the right platform?”

Choose using six criteria:

1. **Where the persona already is** — the platform must be one the target audience actively uses, not one the marketer likes.
2. **B2C vs B2B** — Facebook and Instagram skew B2C; LinkedIn is decisively B2B.
3. **Content format capability** — if the product is visual, Instagram and YouTube; if it needs explanation, LinkedIn and YouTube; if it is real-time, X.
4. **Objective and funnel stage** — awareness (Instagram, YouTube), consideration (LinkedIn, YouTube), conversion (Facebook and Instagram ads with retargeting).
5. **Resources** — each platform demands a distinct content type; better to dominate two than to be mediocre on six.
6. **Measurable ROI** — test with small paid budgets, then concentrate spend where cost per result is lowest.

THE PLATFORM PSYCHOLOGY MATRIX

Each platform serves a **distinct psychological function** in the decision process:

TikTok → **Discovery** (driven by emotion and novelty) · **YouTube** → **Education** (built on retention and perceived expertise) · **ChatGPT/AI** → **Verification** (demands citations and semantic clarity) · **Amazon** → **Purchasing** (relies on social proof and trust) · **Instagram** → **Aspiration** (powered by aspirational identity) · **Reddit** → **Validation** (thrives on raw, unfiltered authenticity) · **Google** → **the click**

2.8 Social Media for Business

2.8.1 Benefits for Business

- **Increased brand awareness** and reach beyond the existing customer base.
- **Better customer interaction** — a direct, two-way, public channel.
- **Cost-effective promotion** relative to traditional media.
- **Improved customer feedback collection** — unsolicited, real-time and honest.
- **Lead generation and social selling** through personal, relevant content.
- **Website traffic and indirect SEO benefit** from shares and links.
- **Competitive intelligence** — competitors' campaigns, offers and customer complaints are public.
- **Crisis detection** — problems surface on social before they reach support tickets.
- **Community and advocacy** — customers become an unpaid distribution network.

2.8.2 The Social Media Marketing Plan

1. **Set goals** aligned to business objectives — awareness, engagement, traffic, leads, sales, retention or service.
2. **Audit the current state** — existing profiles, follower quality, engagement benchmarks, competitor share of voice.
3. **Define the audience and personas** (§2.3).
4. **Select platforms** using the six criteria in §2.7.6.
5. **Define the content strategy** — themes, formats, tone, the 4-1-1 mix, and the lifecycle matrix mapping.
6. **Build the content calendar** — cadence, timing, campaign moments, seasonal hooks.
7. **Assign resources and tools** — who creates, who approves, who publishes, who responds.
8. **Publish and engage** — respond within a defined service-level window.
9. **Amplify** — paid boosting, employee advocacy, influencer partnerships, community seeding.
10. **Measure against KPIs** and optimise the next cycle.

2.8.3 Social Media Marketing Tools

Category	Tools
Scheduling & management	Hootsuite, Buffer, Sprout Social, Later, Zoho Social, Meta Business Suite
Design & creative	Canva, Adobe Express, Figma, CapCut
Analytics	Native platform insights, Sprout Social, Socialbakers, Google Analytics (social acquisition reports)
Listening & monitoring	Brandwatch, Mention, Talkwalker, Google Alerts, Hootsuite Streams
Influencer discovery	Upfluence, Klear, BuzzSumo
Link tracking	Bitly, UTM parameters via Google's Campaign URL Builder

2.8.4 Publishing Blogs, Podcasts and Webinars

Format	Strength	Best used for
Blog	Owned, indexable, compounding SEO asset; full control	Long-tail search capture, thought leadership, evergreen education
Podcast	Intimate, consumed hands-free during commutes and workouts; builds strong parasocial trust	Deep interviews, category authority, loyal niche audience
Webinar	Live, interactive, high-intent; captures registration data	Lead generation, product demonstration, sales enablement, customer training

Webinars are a strong marketing tool because they generate qualified leads at the point of registration, allow live objection handling, position the brand as an expert, can be recorded and repurposed indefinitely (the 4 Rs), and produce measurable attendance and engagement data.

2.8.5 Social Media Monitoring

Social media monitoring — the practice of tracking mentions of your brand, competitors, products, industry keywords and campaign hashtags across social platforms, in order to respond to individual conversations and to extract aggregate insight.

- Key metrics: **mentions**, **followers**, **buzz** (a combined popularity measure), **share of voice** (conversations about you versus about the competition) and **sentiment** (positive, negative or neutral).
- Uses: reputation management, crisis detection, customer service, competitor intelligence, influencer identification and campaign measurement.
- Major tools: **Facebook Insights**, **Twitter/X Analytics**, **Hootsuite**, Brandwatch, Mention, Talkwalker.

2.9 Creation and Optimization of Social Media Campaigns

2.9.1 Elements Required for an Effective Campaign

EXAM ANSWER — CIE-II, 26 May 2026 (2 marks)

Four elements required for an effective social media campaign: **(1) clear campaign objectives, (2) a defined target audience, (3) engaging and creative content, and (4) performance measurement and analytics.**

2.9.2 Building a Campaign — Step by Step

1. **Set a SMART objective** — e.g. “generate 500 qualified leads in 8 weeks at under ₹200 cost per lead”.
2. **Define and segment the target audience** using data-driven insight.
3. **Choose the platform mix** appropriate to that audience and objective.
4. **Develop the creative concept** — a single big idea, a campaign hashtag, and a consistent visual identity.
5. **Produce content mapped to the lifecycle matrix** — early, mid and late-stage assets, scaled through the 4 Rs.
6. **Build the media plan** — organic calendar plus paid budget, audiences and bid strategy.
7. **Set up tracking before launch** — UTM parameters, conversion pixels, goals in analytics.
8. **Launch and engage** actively rather than posting and leaving.
9. **Optimise in flight** (see below).
10. **Report and extract learning** for the next campaign.

2.9.3 Campaign Optimization

EXAM ANSWER — CIE-II, 26 May 2026 (2 marks)

Campaign optimization is the process of improving social media campaign performance by analysing metrics and adjusting content, targeting and advertisements.

Purpose: increase engagement; improve conversion rates; reduce marketing cost; and maximise return on investment (ROI).

What to optimise

Lever	Action
Creative	A/B test images, video hooks, headlines and captions; retire fatigued creative
Copy & CTA	Test tone, length and the specific action verb
Audience & targeting	Narrow or broaden segments; build lookalike audiences from converters; exclude existing customers
Placement	Shift budget between feed, Stories, Reels and Explore based on cost per result
Timing & frequency	Publish when the audience is active; cap frequency to avoid ad fatigue
Budget allocation	Move spend continuously toward the lowest cost-per-result ad set
Landing page	Fix the destination, not just the ad — message match, speed and form friction
Format	Move budget toward video where organic reach and conversion are strongest

2.9.4 Key Metrics for Social Media Campaign Success

SEE Oct/Nov 2023 asked (Q3a, 8 marks): “Discuss the key metrics used to measure the success of a social media marketing campaign and explain the importance of it for evaluating performance.”

Family	Metrics	What it tells you
Reach / Volume	Impressions, reach, follower growth, share of voice	Whether you are being seen at all
Engagement	Likes, comments, shares, saves, engagement rate, video watch time, click-through rate	Whether the content resonates
Traffic	Sessions from social, pages per session, bounce rate	Whether attention transfers to owned property
Conversion	Leads, sign-ups, sales, conversion rate, cost per acquisition, ROAS	Whether it produces business value
Sentiment & advocacy	Sentiment ratio, brand mentions, user-generated content volume, NPS	Whether perception is improving
Efficiency	Cost per click, cost per thousand impressions, cost per lead	Whether the money is being spent well

Why measurement matters: it proves ROI and justifies budget; identifies which content and platforms to scale and which to cut; exposes underperformance early enough to correct it; enables benchmarking against competitors and against past campaigns; and turns opinion-driven decisions into evidence-driven ones.

2.9.5 Facebook and Instagram Across the Funnel

SEE June/July 2025 asked (Q3a, 8 marks): “Analyse how businesses can utilize Facebook and Instagram for different stages of a marketing funnel.”

Funnel stage	Facebook	Instagram
Awareness (top)	Broad reach video ads, Page posts, Facebook Live, Groups seeding	Reels, Explore placement, influencer collaborations, brand Stories
Consideration (middle)	Lead ads, carousel product ads, Messenger conversations, community Groups, event promotion	Story polls and Q&A, guides, tutorial Reels, saved-post content, UGC reposts
Conversion (bottom)	Dynamic product ads, retargeting website visitors and cart abandoners, catalogue ads, offer claims	Instagram Shopping tags, product stickers in Stories, swipe-up/link stickers, DM-based selling
Retention & advocacy (post-purchase)	Customer Groups, Messenger support, loyalty offers	Close Friends offers, UGC contests, highlight reels of customer content

2.10 Search Engine Optimization — Fundamentals

2.10.1 Definition and Objective

DEFINITION

Search Engine Optimization (SEO) is the set of techniques used to improve the visibility and ranking of a website in the *organic* (unpaid) results of search engines, thereby increasing the quantity and quality of traffic to that site.

PRIMARY OBJECTIVE — SEE Jun/Jul 2025 (2 marks)

The primary objective of SEO is to **increase organic visibility for relevant queries** so that the right people — those actively searching with intent — find the site, and to increase the site's usability so that they are satisfied when they arrive. Visibility without relevance is worthless.

2.10.2 Why SEO Matters

- **10 billion** searches happen every day on Google.
- **53% of all website traffic** is delivered by organic search alone.
- Organic traffic has **infinite lifespan** — it compounds, whereas paid traffic stops the moment the budget stops.
- Search traffic carries the **highest buyer intent** of any channel, because the user has explicitly stated their need.
- **Importance for online businesses:** lower customer acquisition cost, credibility (users trust organic results more than ads), 24/7 lead generation, competitive defence, and measurable results.

2.10.3 SEO, SEM and PPC — The Visibility Matrix

Term	Mechanism	Cost model
SEO	Drives <i>organic</i> results and clicks	Free per click; costs time and resources
PPC (Pay Per Click)	Drives <i>paid</i> results; advertisers bid on specific keywords	Advertiser is charged per click
SEM (Search Engine Marketing)	The umbrella term combining both organic and paid search strategies	Both

On a search engine results page, paid listings appear at the top and organic results below them.

2.10.4 The Search Engine Result Page (SERP)

SERP — the page a search engine returns in response to a query. It is no longer a simple list of ten blue links.

Main elements and result types on a modern SERP:

- **Paid results** — search ads at the top and bottom, shopping/product listing ads, local service ads.
- **Organic results** — the ranked list of web pages, each with a title tag, URL and meta description.
- **Featured snippet (“position zero”)** — a direct answer extracted from a page.
- **Knowledge panel and knowledge graph** — entity information drawn from structured sources.
- **Local pack / map pack** — three local businesses with map, ratings and directions.

- **People Also Ask** — expandable related questions; an excellent content-research source.
- **Rich results** — reviews, star ratings, FAQs, recipes, events, driven by structured data markup.
- **Image, video and news carousels**, and **related searches** at the foot of the page.

The three main types of results are therefore **paid, organic and universal/vertical results** (images, video, news, local and shopping).

2.10.5 The AI Shift — From Keywords to Intent

Since **2015**, Google's **RankBrain** and **Hummingbird** algorithms have focused on understanding *user intent* rather than matching keyword strings. They expect high-quality semantic data and well-structured outlines, not keyword stuffing.

E-E-A-T

Google evaluates content on **Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness and Trustworthiness**. Alongside this: **link gravity beats quantity** — a large quantity of *quality* links is the goal, not simply a large quantity of links.

THE POST-PANDA REALITY

Keyword stuffing is dead. Google's sole objective is surfacing the most relevant answer to a query. If the query is "how to make banana bread", your content must provide the best, most readable, fastest answer. **White-hat optimisation** means writing naturally, organising flow well, and *earning* backlinks by creating remarkable, link-worthy data or insight.

2.11 The SEO Process — Six Steps

An SEO project follows six steps. Note that SEO does not begin and end with initial work — ongoing success requires monitoring results and building meaningful content continually.

Step	Activity
1. Keyword Research	Identify a group of keyword phrases balancing high usage by searchers with relatively low competition . Also perform competitive research — a thorough analysis against the site's 7–10 biggest competitors using SEO metrics such as indexed content, inbound links, domain age and social following, to gauge the starting position and identify priorities.
2. Reporting & Goal Setting	Establish the site's current position in the search engines and its traffic baseline (which engines, which phrases, bounce rates, most popular content). Set measurable goals tied to specific business objectives.
3. Content Building	Content is king. High-volume, high-quality content gives users a reason to stay and return, and gives search engines more information to store — which translates directly into rankings.
4. Page Optimization	On-page work: page titles, text-based navigation, prominence of targeted keyword phrases, site map, ALT and META data, and cleaning up the code.
5. Social & Link Building	Establish a social media presence to share content (“fish where the fish are”), and build high-quality inbound links. Google views links from high-quality sites as votes for your site.
6. Follow-up Reporting & Analysis	Repeat the initial reporting at regular intervals post-optimisation. Compare rankings, traffic, social signals and other key metrics against pre-optimisation levels to produce measurable results.

2.11.1 SEO Goals

- The ultimate goal is to **increase the site's usability** so that the right people are brought in from the search engines. The purpose of the site must be clearly defined so you can ensure the site achieves it.
- When search visitors find that the site meets their expectations after clicking through, **usability is solid**. If they are disappointed, the site has missed its mark.
- Follow the best strategies for ranking, which requires understanding how search engines want things done — familiarise yourself with their terms and conditions and Webmaster guidelines.
- Use **white-hat techniques** — those that fall in line with what search engines define as best practice. Black-hat shortcuts (keyword stuffing, cloaking, link farms, hidden text, doorway pages) produce short-term gains and long-term penalties.

2.12 Keywords and the SEO Content Plan

2.12.1 Why Keyword Research Matters

EXAM ANSWER — CIE-II 07.05.2025 (2 marks)

Keyword research matters because it reveals **the exact language real users type**, the **volume of demand** behind each phrase, the **competition** for it and the **intent** behind it. Without it, content is optimised for phrases nobody searches, effort is spent on terms that cannot realistically be ranked for, and traffic arrives with no intent to buy.

2.12.2 Types of Keyword by Intent

Intent type	What the user wants	Example
Informational	To learn something	"what is content marketing"
Navigational	To reach a specific site	"RVCE login"
Commercial investigation	To compare before buying	"best trekking shoes under 5000"
Transactional	To buy now	"buy trekking shoes online"

Keywords are also classified by length: **head/short-tail** (1–2 words, huge volume, brutal competition, vague intent), **body** (2–3 words), and **long-tail** (4+ words, low volume each but collectively the majority of all searches, low competition, sharp intent and high conversion).

2.12.3 Finding the Keyword Sweet Spot

A keyword is worth targeting only where three conditions overlap.

- **High search volume** — a minimum of roughly **250–1,000+ monthly searches**.
- **Low SEO difficulty** — under about a **40 SD/KD score**, so ranking is realistically achievable.
- **Commercial intent** — high cost-per-click and buyer-specific phrasing, indicating the searcher intends to transact.

WARNING

Traffic without intent is useless. Do not optimise for clicks; optimise for revenue.

2.12.4 Building an SEO Content Plan

1. **Define business objectives** first — what does the site actually need (sales, leads, sign-ups)?
2. **Research keywords** and cluster them into topics rather than isolated phrases.
3. **Map intent to funnel stage** — informational keywords become blog content; commercial and transactional keywords become product and comparison pages.
4. **Audit existing content** — decide what to keep, update, consolidate or retire.
5. **Identify content gaps** against competitors — topics with demand where nobody ranks well.
6. **Design the site architecture** — a pillar page per topic cluster, with supporting articles internally linked to it.
7. **Assign one primary keyword per page** — never make two pages compete for the same term (keyword cannibalisation).
8. **Build the editorial calendar** with owners, deadlines and target keywords.
9. **Set measurable targets** — rankings, impressions, organic sessions, assisted conversions.
10. **Review and iterate** monthly.

2.12.5 Aligning SEO with Business Objectives

Business objective	SEO focus	Primary KPI
Increase online sales	Transactional and product keywords; optimised category and product pages; rich results with reviews and price	Organic revenue, organic conversion rate
Generate leads	Commercial-investigation keywords; comparison and "best X for Y" content; gated assets	Organic leads, cost per lead

Business objective	SEO focus	Primary KPI
Build brand authority	Informational pillar content; E-E-A-T signals; digital PR and backlinks	Impressions, non-branded keyword coverage, referring domains
Reduce paid ad dependence	Rank organically for the terms currently being bought	Share of traffic from organic vs paid
Enter a new market	Local and language-specific SEO; localised content and listings	Local pack visibility, regional organic sessions

2.13 Writing SEO Content

2.13.1 Anatomy of a Top-Ranking Page

- **H1 title** — click-worthy, exact-match keyword headline.
- **Introduction** — comprehensive, answering the user's core intent immediately rather than after 400 words of preamble.
- **Structure** — H2/H3 subheadings containing LSI (long-tail) keyword variants.
- **Formatting** — short, scannable paragraphs and bulleted lists.
- **Rich media** — embedded videos and infographics to increase dwell time.
- **Architecture** — internal links to keep users inside your ecosystem, plus credible outbound links to build trust.

2.13.2 Integrating Keywords Naturally

CIE-II of 24 July 2024 asked: *“You are writing a blog post about a complex technical topic. Describe how you would integrate relevant keywords naturally into the content while ensuring it remains engaging and informative for readers.”*

1. **Write for the reader first, then optimise.** Draft the piece to genuinely answer the question, then place keywords during editing.
2. **Place the primary keyword in the high-value positions** — title tag, H1, first 100 words, one H2, the URL slug, the meta description and one image ALT attribute.
3. **Use semantic variants and synonyms (LSI terms)** rather than repeating the exact phrase; modern algorithms understand meaning, not string matching.
4. **Respect keyword density.** Industry practice is roughly **3–5%** for the focus phrase — enough to signal topic, not enough to read as spam. Never stuff.
5. **Answer the sub-questions** surfaced in “People Also Ask”; each becomes an H2 or H3 that naturally carries a long-tail variant.
6. **Explain jargon on first use** and use analogies, examples, diagrams and code snippets to keep a technical topic engaging.
7. **Break up the text** with subheadings, lists, tables and visuals every few paragraphs.
8. **Link internally** with keyword-rich but descriptive anchor text.
9. **Read it aloud.** If a sentence sounds unnatural because of a keyword, rewrite it — user signals now outweigh keyword placement.

2.13.3 Key Considerations When Writing SEO-Friendly Content

- **Search intent match** — the format must match what already ranks (a list, a guide, a comparison, a tool).
- **Originality and depth** — content must be better than what currently occupies the SERP, not merely equivalent.
- **Readability** — short sentences, plain language, scannable structure.
- **Freshness** — update statistics and examples; stale content loses rankings.
- **Unique title tags and meta descriptions** on every page.
- **Accessibility** — descriptive ALT text on every meaningful image.
- **Comprehensiveness** — cover the topic fully so the user has no reason to return to the SERP.

2.14 On-Site (On-Page) SEO

DEFINITION

On-page / on-site SEO refers to how well a website's own content and code are presented to search engines. It involves ensuring that a particular webpage is structured so that it is found for given keywords and key phrases. It improves search ranking *and* the overall readability of the site, and — unlike off-page work — it can be improved immediately by fixing incorrect elements on the page.

2.14.1 The Five Key Elements

Element	What to do
1. Page copy	Produce original, unique, high-quality, relevant content continuously. Focus each piece on a single primary keyword or key phrase , maintaining a keyword density of about 3–5% , mixing primary and secondary phrases. Quality over quantity — depth and content intensity have outperformed sheer length since the 2011 Google algorithm update.
2. Title tags	Arguably the most important element of the “big three” (the others being page copy and inbound links). The title tag supplies the clickable link in the search result. Google limits page titles to about 70 characters , so titles must be keyword-relevant yet concise. Order: primary keyword, then secondary keyword, then branded keyword at the end — except on the home page.
3. Meta data	A well-written description summarising the page, limited to 155–160 characters . Meta keywords lost ranking influence after Google's September 2009 declaration because of spam abuse, but crawlers still read them for topicality. The meta description cannot influence rankings but strongly influences click-through rate — it works as ad copy for the organic result, and Google highlights matching keywords in bold.
4. Heading tags	Define the content section by section, like traditional headings and subheadings. There should be one `<h1>` per page containing the most relevant key phrase. Tags run to `<h6>`, though general practice uses up to `<h3>`. Place other important key phrases in `<h2>` and `<h3>`.
5. Interlinking	Linking one page of your site to related pages provides context to both search engines and readers.

2.14.2 Interlinking Best Practices

1. Include links in the **main content** of each page.
2. **Paragraph links carry the most weight.**
3. Use **keyword-rich anchor text**.
4. Avoid non-descriptive anchor text such as “read more” or “click here”.
5. Link to **relevant, deep pages** — not only the home page.
6. Use **breadcrumb navigation** on every page.
7. **Monitor inbound links** through Google Search Console.
8. Avoid multiple links to the same page from a single page.
9. **Fewer links = more authority per link.**

2.14.3 Technical SEO — The Defence

“SEO is like a sports team. To win, both defence and offence are required.” Technical SEO is the foundation of the house: the architecture that allows the site to be crawled and indexed at all.

- **Site speed and Core Web Vitals** (LCP, INP, CLS).

- **Mobile friendliness** and responsive design.
- **HTTPS** security.
- **XML sitemap** and a correct `robots.txt`.
- **Crawlability and indexing** — no orphan pages, no broken links, no redirect chains.
- **Clean URL structure** — short, readable, keyword-bearing.
- **Canonical tags** to prevent duplicate-content dilution.
- **Structured data / schema markup** for rich results.
- **Avoid intrusive interstitials** and pop-ups that block content on mobile.

TWO TECHNICAL ASPECTS — CIE-II QUIZ, 24 July 2024 (2 marks)

“Name two technical aspects of a website that can significantly impact its organic search ranking.” Best two answers: **site loading speed (Core Web Vitals)** and **mobile responsiveness**. Also acceptable: HTTPS security, crawlability/indexability, XML sitemap, URL structure.

2.15 Off-Site (Off-Page) SEO

DEFINITION

Off-page / off-site SEO refers to a website's overall **authority** on the web, determined by what *other* websites say about it. It is a long-term process. Put simply, off-page is about your **online reputation**. Its central activity is acquiring backlinks from authority sites in your niche — **backlinks are the currency of any off-page strategy**. Unlike on-page work, off-page effort is not visible on the webpage itself; it does the background work for a better search result.

2.15.1 The Two Halves of Off-Page Work

1. Acquiring backlinks. Search engines treat link popularity as a key ranking factor, though it is no longer the top factor because it can be manipulated. After the **Google Panda and Penguin** updates, many effective old-school practices became obsolete and negatively affected large, high-ranking websites. Engines now focus more on **content quality and engagement level** than on the raw number of links. The success factor is not building a long list of inbound links but building a trail of **quality** links.

THE LINK RULE

Getting links from **multiple relevant domains** in your industry is the key. **Link gravity beats quantity** — a large quantity of *quality* links is the goal.

2. Building brand signals — brand mentions, reviews, ratings, social sharing, PR coverage and demand generation, all of which contribute to E-E-A-T.

2.15.2 Off-Page Techniques

- **Digital PR and link earning** — publish original research, data or tools that journalists and bloggers cite naturally.
- **Guest posting** on relevant, authoritative sites in the niche.
- **Broken-link building** — find dead links on relevant pages and offer your resource as a replacement.
- **Business listings and citations** — Google Business Profile, industry directories, consistent NAP (name, address, phone).

- **Online reviews and ratings** on Google, industry platforms and marketplaces.
- **Social media sharing** — not a direct ranking factor, but it produces the exposure from which links follow.
- **Influencer and expert collaborations** — interviews, quotes and co-created content.
- **Forum and community participation** — Quora, Reddit and niche communities, contributing genuine value.
- **Unlinked-mention reclamation** — find places where the brand is mentioned without a link and request one.

2.15.3 On-Site vs Off-Site SEO — The Comparison Table

Asked as a 2-mark question (CIE-II 07.05.2025) and as a 10-mark question in the same paper: “Analyse the differences between on-site and off-site SEO techniques. Provide examples for each.”

Basis	On-Site (On-Page) SEO	Off-Site (Off-Page) SEO
Location of work	Within your own website	Outside your website
What it controls	How content and code are presented to search engines	The site's authority and reputation across the web
Primary target	Humans and crawlers reading the page	Third-party validators — other sites and users
Core challenge	Quality and formatting	Brand authority
Degree of control	Complete — you own it	Limited — others decide
Speed of effect	Immediate; can be fixed today	Slow; a long-term process
Techniques	Title tags, meta descriptions, heading tags, keyword placement, content quality, internal linking, image ALT text, URL structure, site speed, mobile friendliness	Backlink building, guest posting, digital PR, social sharing, influencer collaboration, online reviews, business listings, forum participation
Example	Rewriting a product page title to “Trekking Shoes for Men — Waterproof — BrandName”	Earning a link from a national outdoors magazine's “best trekking gear” article

2.15.4 The House of SEO — The Full Picture

	Technical SEO (The Defence)	On-Page SEO	Off-Page SEO (The Offence)
Position	The foundation / basement	The living floor	The roof / attic
Primary target	Search engine bots	Humans and algorithms	Third-party validators
Core challenge	Discoverability and security	Quality and formatting	Brand authority
The goal	100% crawlability, indexing and seamless UX infrastructure	Publish well-written, original, error-free content better than SERP competitors	Enhance brand awareness and recognition; acquire high-quality backlinks
Elements	URL structure, HTTPS, mobile friendliness, Core Web Vitals, fast hosting, avoiding intrusive interstitials	Relevant topics, title tags, H1–H6 headers, image ALT text, multimedia	Link building, PR, ratings, demand generation, E-E-A-T

2.16 Optimizing Organic Search Ranking

2.16.1 Purpose

EXAM ANSWER — CIE-II 07.05.2025 (2 marks)

The purpose of optimising organic search rankings is to **appear higher in unpaid search results for queries with real commercial intent**, thereby capturing sustainable, high-quality, zero-marginal-cost traffic; reducing dependence on paid advertising; and building the credibility that comes with ranking organically rather than paying for position.

2.16.2 Key Metrics Used to Measure Organic Search Ranking

CIE-II of 24 July 2024 asked this as a full 10-mark question together with the SEO audit process.

Metric	What it measures
Average position / keyword rankings	Where the site sits for its target keywords
Organic impressions	How often pages are shown in search results
Organic clicks and organic CTR	How often people actually click — and how compelling the title and meta description are
Organic sessions / traffic	Volume of visitors arriving from unpaid search
Keyword coverage	The number of distinct keywords ranking in the top 3, top 10 and top 100
Indexed pages	How much of the site the engine has actually stored
Referring domains and backlink quality	Off-page authority growth
Domain / page authority	Third-party authority scoring (Moz, Ahrefs)
Bounce rate and dwell time	Whether the traffic finds what it expected
Organic conversions and assisted conversions	Whether the traffic produces business value
Core Web Vitals	Technical experience signals feeding into ranking

2.16.3 Conducting an SEO Audit

1. **Crawl the site** (Screaming Frog, SEMrush Site Audit, Ahrefs Site Audit) to find broken links, redirect chains, duplicate titles and descriptions, missing H1s, thin pages and orphan pages.
2. **Check indexation** in Google Search Console — are the important pages actually indexed? Are unimportant ones consuming crawl budget?
3. **Audit technical health** — speed, Core Web Vitals, mobile usability, HTTPS, sitemap, robots.txt, canonical tags, structured data.
4. **Audit on-page elements** — title tags, meta descriptions, heading hierarchy, keyword targeting, keyword cannibalisation, image ALT text, internal linking.
5. **Audit content** — relevance, depth, freshness, originality, intent match, and gaps against competitors.
6. **Audit backlinks** — referring domains, anchor-text distribution, toxic links to disavow, and the link gap versus competitors.
7. **Benchmark competitors** on the same metrics to establish relative position.

8. **Prioritise findings** by impact versus effort, and produce a ranked action plan.
9. **Implement, then re-measure** at defined intervals against the pre-optimisation baseline.

WORKED EXAMPLE — the educational institution that cannot rank for “online courses”

(CIE-II, 24 July 2024, 10 marks)

Likely issues: targeting head keywords far above the site's authority; thin course pages with duplicate descriptions; no topic-cluster architecture; slow, unoptimised pages; no schema markup for courses; very few referring domains compared with established ed-tech competitors; no student-facing informational content capturing early-funnel search.

Recommended actions: (1) shift targeting to achievable **long-tail** phrases (“online data analytics course for working professionals in Bengaluru”); (2) build a pillar page per subject area with supporting articles internally linked; (3) rewrite every course page with unique titles, meta descriptions, outcomes, fees, faculty and FAQs; (4) add **Course** and **FAQ schema** for rich results; (5) fix speed and mobile usability; (6) earn links through original placement-outcome research, faculty guest articles and local news coverage; (7) build reviews on Google Business Profile and education directories; (8) measure keyword coverage, organic sessions and enquiry conversions monthly.

2.16.4 Why SEO Must Be Integrated Into Website Development

SEE June/July 2025 asked (2 marks): “Why is it important to integrate SEO in website development?”

- Site architecture, URL structure and navigation are extremely expensive to change after launch but nearly free to get right during build.
- Rendering method, page speed and Core Web Vitals are determined by development decisions, not by marketing decisions.
- Retro-fitting SEO usually forces URL changes, which risk losing accumulated ranking authority.
- Content structure (heading hierarchy, schema, internal linking) must be designed into the templates.
- Tracking and analytics must be instrumented before launch, not after traffic is lost.
- It avoids launching with pages blocked by `robots.txt` or `noindex` left over from staging — a classic and costly error.

2.16.5 The Human–Algorithm Symbiosis

WHY GOOD DESIGN IS NOW GOOD SEO

Algorithms (SEO) care about crawlability, keywords, metadata and links. **Humans (design)** care about scanning, speed, usability and satisfaction. The **overlap** is **Core Web Vitals** (speed and stability) and **E-E-A-T** (trust and authority).

Search engines have evolved to mimic human preferences. **Good web usability is now a fundamental requirement for good SEO.**

2.16.6 Search Everywhere Optimization — SEO 2.0

A forward-looking extension of the syllabus, and directly relevant to questions about new digital channels.

- **13.7 billion** daily searches happen on the internet, and **73% of all searches happen outside Google**. Most marketers are still playing a Google-only game — even a business winning at Google can be losing customers.
- **The symptom vs the disease:** traffic looks decent but conversions are flat. You are showing up for the *search* but missing the *decision*. The disease is optimising for visibility in one place while the customer is

deciding everywhere else.

- **The paradigm shift:** consumers aren't just *searching* — they are **deciding**, and decision-making is distributed across many platforms simultaneously.
- **The death of the funnel:** the modern journey is not funnel-shaped and linear. It is a **decision constellation** of micro-choices happening in different places at the same time — Click → Google, Trust → Reddit, Buy → Amazon, Try → Google Play, Think → YouTube/podcasts, Believe → AI assistants, Follow → Instagram, Better → YouTube.
- **Visibility vs Validation:** *visibility* is what you do (showing up in the search engine, creating platform-specific posts). *Validation* is what others say about what you do (organic mentions in conversations, authentic social proof). **Visibility without validation is just noise** — you need both to secure the decision.
- **Prioritisation — the RICE framework:** **Reach** (how many users in your specific audience will this micro-decision impact?), **Impact** (how deeply does this platform influence the final purchase decision?), **Confidence** (how certain are you that your brand can execute authentically here?), **Ease** (what operational effort is required to maintain a strategic presence?). You don't have to be everywhere — you need a prioritisation strategy.

2.17 SEO Tools

Category	Tools
All-in-one SEO suites	SEMrush, Ahrefs, Moz Pro, Ubersuggest, SE Ranking
Google's own tools	Google Search Console, Google Analytics 4, Keyword Planner, PageSpeed Insights, Trends, Rich Results Test, Tag Manager
Keyword research	Keyword Planner, SEMrush Keyword Magic Tool, Ahrefs Keywords Explorer, AnswerThePublic, AlsoAsked
Technical crawling	Screaming Frog SEO Spider, Sitebulb, DeepCrawl
Backlink analysis	Ahrefs, Majestic, Moz Link Explorer, SEMrush Backlink Audit
Rank tracking	SEMrush Position Tracking, AccuRanker, SERPWatcher
Content optimisation	Surfer SEO, Clearscope, Yoast SEO / Rank Math (WordPress)
Competitive intelligence	SimilarWeb, SpyFu, BuzzSumo

2.18 Key Terms — Quick Revision

Term	One-line meaning
SMM	Creating and sharing content on social networks to achieve marketing and branding goals
Customer Lifecycle Orbit	Awareness → Engagement → Purchase → Retention/Loyalty → Growth → Advocacy
Content Lifecycle Matrix	Early / Mid / Late-stage mapping of objective, tone and format
4-1-1 rule	4 value posts + 1 soft promo + 1 hard promo (Joe Pulizzi)
4 Rs of Content Scaling	Reorganize, Rewrite, Retire, Redesign
Facebook Algorithm Filter	The ranking system deciding which posts reach the news feed
Engagement bait	Explicitly asking for likes/shares/comments — penalised by the algorithm
Hashtag	A '#'-prefixed searchable label grouping posts on a topic
Share of voice	Conversations about your brand versus conversations about competitors
Campaign optimization	Improving campaign performance by analysing metrics and adjusting content, targeting and ads
SEO	Improving organic visibility and ranking in search engines
SEM	Umbrella term for SEO + PPC
SERP	Search Engine Results Page
On-page SEO	How well your own content and code are presented to search engines
Off-page SEO	Your site's authority determined by what other sites say about it
Technical SEO	The crawlable, indexable, fast, secure infrastructure of the site
Backlink	An inbound link from another site — the currency of off-page SEO
Keyword density	Share of the content occupied by the focus keyword; industry norm 3–5%
LSI keywords	Semantically related long-tail variants of the primary keyword
E-E-A-T	Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness
RankBrain / Hummingbird	Google algorithms (from 2015) focused on user intent, not keyword strings
Panda / Penguin	Google updates penalising thin content and manipulative link-building
Long-tail keyword	A 4+ word phrase — low volume, low competition, high intent
Keyword cannibalisation	Two of your own pages competing for the same keyword
White-hat / Black-hat SEO	Techniques within search-engine guidelines / techniques that violate them

2.19 Previous Year Questions — Unit II

A. Two-Mark Questions (Part A)

1. What is meant by data-driven audience insight in Social Media Marketing? [CIE-II 26 May 2026]

The process of collecting and analysing user data — demographics, interests, online behaviour, engagement patterns and preferences — from social media platforms to understand the target audience better. It helps marketers create personalised campaigns and improve customer engagement.

2. List any four elements required for creating an effective social media campaign. [CIE-II 26 May 2026]

Clear campaign objectives; a defined target audience; engaging and creative content; performance measurement and analytics.

3. Define campaign optimization in Social Media Marketing and mention its purpose. [CIE-II 26 May 2026]

The process of improving social media campaign performance by analysing metrics and adjusting content, targeting and advertisements. Purpose: increase engagement, improve conversion rates, reduce marketing cost and maximise ROI.

4. List any four benefits of using social media platforms for business marketing and customer engagement. [CIE-II 26 May 2026]

Increased brand awareness; better customer interaction; cost-effective promotion; improved customer feedback collection.

5. What is the primary goal of social media marketing? [SEE Jun/Jul 2025]

To build brand awareness and engagement with a target audience on social platforms, and to convert that engagement into traffic, leads, sales and long-term customer loyalty.

6. Define Hashtag. List the importance of Hashtag in social media marketing. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023]

A hashtag is a word or phrase prefixed with `#` that becomes a clickable, searchable label grouping all posts on that topic. Importance: increases discoverability beyond existing followers; groups a campaign under one trackable label; enables participation in trending conversations; collects user-generated content; and provides a measurable unit for campaign reporting.

7. Why is keyword research important in SEO? [CIE-II 07.05.2025] / What is keyword research in SEO? [SEE Oct/Nov 2023]

Keyword research is the process of identifying the phrases that real users type into search engines, together with their search volume, competition and intent. It matters because it ensures content targets phrases that people actually search, that the site can realistically rank for, and that carry commercial intent — so effort produces revenue rather than vanity traffic.

8. Differentiate between On-site SEO and Off-site SEO. [CIE-II 07.05.2025]

On-site SEO is work done within your own website — title tags, meta descriptions, headings, content quality, keyword placement, internal linking, site speed — controlling how content is presented to search engines. **Off-site SEO** is work done outside your website — backlinks, digital PR, social sharing, reviews, listings — building the site's authority and reputation as judged by other sites.

9. What is the purpose of optimizing organic search rankings in SEO? [CIE-II 07.05.2025]

To appear higher in unpaid results for commercially relevant queries, capturing sustainable high-intent traffic at near-zero marginal cost, reducing dependence on paid advertising and gaining the credibility of

an organic listing.

10. What is the primary objective of Search Engine Optimization (SEO)? [SEE Jun/Jul 2025]

To increase the quantity and quality of organic traffic by improving the site's visibility and ranking for relevant queries, and to ensure the site satisfies the intent of the visitors it attracts.

11. Why is it important to integrate SEO in website development? [SEE Jun/Jul 2025]

Because architecture, URLs, rendering, speed, heading structure and tracking are all determined at build time. Retro-fitting SEO later is expensive, forces URL changes that risk losing accumulated authority, and often leaves staging `noindex` directives in production.

12. Name two technical aspects of a website that can significantly impact its organic search ranking. [CIE-II Quiz 24 Jul 2024]

Site loading speed / Core Web Vitals, and mobile responsiveness. (Also acceptable: HTTPS, crawlability and indexability, XML sitemap, URL structure.)

13. Define SEO and explain why it is important for online businesses. [CIE-II Quiz 24 Jul 2024]

SEO is the set of techniques used to improve a website's visibility and ranking in the organic results of search engines. It matters to online businesses because organic search delivers about 53% of all website traffic, carries the highest buyer intent of any channel, costs nothing per click, compounds over time, and confers more credibility than paid listings.

14. What are two key considerations when writing SEO-friendly content for web pages? [CIE-II Quiz 24 Jul 2024]

(1) **Match the search intent** — the format and depth must answer what the user actually wants. (2) **Integrate keywords naturally** in the title, H1, opening paragraph and subheadings using semantic variants, at roughly 3–5% density, without stuffing. (Also acceptable: unique title tag and meta description; scannable structure.)

B. Ten-Mark and Eight-Mark Questions (Part B)

1. Analyse how the Facebook Algorithm Filter evaluates content distribution. What specific practices are penalized (filtered out) and which ones are rewarded (propelled through)? [CIE-II 26 May 2026 — asked twice]

See §2.7.2. Structure the answer as: (i) what the algorithm is and why it exists; (ii) the five evaluation criteria — engagement history, relevance, content type preference, timeliness, quality/originality; (iii) the penalised list — clickbait headlines, repeated sources posted back-to-back, engagement bait, fake news, spam, low-quality copied content, excessive promotion; (iv) the rewarded list — time spent on the post after full load, video actions (unmuting, full-screen, HD), Facebook Live (300% more watch time than recorded video), original content, meaningful interactions, informative posts, consistent posting.

2. Based on “The Content Lifecycle Matrix,” how should a marketer adjust the objective, tone, and format of their content as a prospect transitions from the Early-Stage to the Late-Stage? [CIE-II 26 May 2026]

Reproduce the 3×3 matrix in §2.4 and then explain the trajectory: objective moves from *attention* to *trust* to *action*; tone moves from fun and entertaining to educational to informative and conversion-focused; format moves from curated news, tips and visual content to contests, newsletter subscriptions and event invitations, and finally to click-to-purchase, demos and trial sign-ups.

3. Explain the stages of “The Customer Lifecycle Orbit” and discuss the statistical differences in selling to new prospects versus existing customers. [CIE-II 26 May 2026]

See §2.2. Name and explain the six stages, then give the statistics: probability of selling to a new prospect is roughly 5–20%, versus 60–70% for an existing customer; repeat customers spend up to 67% more; 49% of marketers achieve higher ROI by focusing on engagement. Conclude with the implication — retention is structurally cheaper and more profitable than acquisition, so social content must serve the whole orbit, not just awareness.

4. Detail the “4 Rs of Content Scaling.” How does this strategic framework help marketers maximize the use of their content assets? [CIE-II 26 May 2026]

See §2.6. Give Reorganize, Rewrite, Retire and Redesign with an example each, note the alternative Repurpose/Refresh/Repost/Recombine formulation, and close with the benefits — saves time and cost, increases reach, improves SEO performance, enhances engagement and maximises ROI from content assets.

5. Explain the importance of social media marketing for businesses today. How can businesses integrate social media platforms into their overall marketing strategy? [CIE-II 07.05.2025]

Importance — the trust asymmetry (90% believe peers, 48% trust businesses), reach, cost-effectiveness, two-way engagement, feedback, social selling and SEO fuel. Integration — the omnichannel gearbox (§2.1.3), the ten-step SMM plan (§2.8.2), mapping content to the customer lifecycle orbit, and synchronising social with website, e-mail, search and offline channels so the customer experiences one continuous conversation.

6. Compare the roles of Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, and Twitter in social media marketing. How should a business choose the right platform? [CIE-II 07.05.2025]

Use the platform deployment matrix (§2.7.1) covering core mechanic, best use and key features for each, then the six selection criteria in §2.7.6, closing with the platform psychology matrix — each platform serves a different psychological function in the decision.

7. Explain the importance of data-driven insights in social media marketing. Describe the process of developing audience insights using social media analytics tools. How can these insights inform the development and optimization of social media campaigns? [CIE-I 1 Jul 2024]

See §2.3. Cover the definition, the eight-step insight process, the tools, and then the application — targeting, creative, tone, format, schedule and budget allocation, plus in-flight optimisation using the levers in §2.9.3.

8. Illustrate how social media analytics contribute to creating audience profiles. [SEE Jun/Jul 2025, Q4a]

See §2.3.4 — the seven layers: demographic, temporal, interest, behavioural, conversational, comparative and conversion.

9. Analyse how businesses can utilize Facebook and Instagram for different stages of a marketing funnel. [SEE Jun/Jul 2025, Q3a]

See the funnel table in §2.9.5, covering awareness, consideration, conversion and retention/advocacy on both platforms.

10. Discuss the key metrics used to measure the success of a social media marketing campaign and explain the importance of it for evaluating performance. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023, Q3a]

See §2.9.4 — the six metric families and the six reasons measurement matters.

11. Analyse the differences between on-site and off-site SEO techniques. Provide examples for each. [CIE-II 07.05.2025]

Use the comparison table in §2.15.3 and the House of SEO in §2.15.4, with the worked examples given there.

12. Explain the key components of Search Engine Optimization (SEO), including on-page, off-page, and technical SEO. How do these elements contribute to improving website ranking on search engines? [CIE-I 16 Apr 2026]

On-page SEO (content optimisation) — keyword optimisation in titles, headings and content; meta tags; URL structure; internal linking; high-quality relevant content. **Off-page SEO (external factors)** — backlinks from other websites; social media sharing; influencer collaborations; online reviews. **Technical SEO (backend optimisation)** — website speed; mobile friendliness; secure HTTPS; XML sitemap; crawlability and indexing. Then explain the contribution: technical SEO makes the site *discoverable*, on-page SEO makes it *relevant*, and off-page SEO makes it *authoritative* — and rankings are a function of all three together.

13. What are the key metrics used to measure organic search ranking? How can businesses monitor and improve these metrics over time? Describe the process of conducting an SEO audit and implementing changes to optimize organic search ranking. [CIE-II 24 Jul 2024]

See §2.16.2 for the metric table and §2.16.3 for the nine-step audit process, closing with the six-step SEO process (§2.11) as the ongoing improvement cycle.

14. An educational institution is struggling to rank for competitive keywords related to online courses. Conduct an SEO audit of their website, identify key issues affecting organic search ranking, and recommend actionable solutions. [CIE-II 24 Jul 2024]

See the worked example box in §2.16.3.

15. You are writing a blog post about a complex technical topic. Describe how you would integrate relevant keywords naturally into the content while ensuring it remains engaging and informative for readers. [CIE-II 24 Jul 2024]

See §2.13.2 — the nine-point method, anchored on “write for the reader first, then optimise”, keyword placement in high-value positions, semantic variants, 3–5% density, People-Also-Ask coverage, jargon explanation, visual breaks, internal linking and a read-aloud check.

16. Develop an SEO content plan for an e-commerce startup targeting eco-friendly household products. [SEE Jun/Jul 2025, Q3b]

Objective: organic revenue from high-intent shoppers within 9 months. **Keyword research:** cluster into topics — *eco-friendly cleaning*, *plastic-free kitchen*, *sustainable laundry*, *bamboo and natural fibre goods* — targeting long-tail commercial phrases such as “biodegradable dishwashing liquid India” (volume 250–1,000+, KD under 40, clear buyer intent). **Architecture:** one pillar page per cluster, supported by product and comparison pages, all internally linked. **Content plan by intent:** informational blogs (“how harmful are conventional detergents?”), commercial comparisons (“best plastic-free kitchen swaps”), and transactional category and product pages with unique copy. **On-page:** unique title tags under 70 characters, 155–160 character meta descriptions, one H1 per page, ALT text on all product images, 3–5% keyword density, breadcrumb navigation. **Technical:** fast mobile-first storefront, HTTPS, XML sitemap, Product and Review schema for rich results, canonical tags on filtered category URLs. **Off-page:** digital PR on plastic-waste data, guest posts on sustainability blogs, Google Business Profile, review generation. **Measurement:** keyword coverage, organic sessions, organic conversion rate and revenue, reviewed monthly.

17. Construct a targeted marketing plan using SEO tools like Google Analytics and SEMrush for a B2B company. [SEE Jun/Jul 2025, Q4b]

Step 1 — Baseline in Google Analytics 4: identify current organic sessions, top landing pages, acquisition channels, and which pages assist conversions. **Step 2 — Opportunity analysis in SEMrush:** run Organic Research on the top 5 competitors, use Keyword Gap to find phrases they rank for and you do not, and Keyword Magic Tool to build clusters around the buyer's problems. **Step 3 — Persona and intent**

mapping: align keywords to the 4–6 B2B personas (Executive Sponsor, Decision Maker, End User), matching informational content to early-stage roles and commercial content to decision makers. **Step 4 — Content plan:** pillar pages per solution area, supported by case studies, ROI calculators, whitepapers and comparison pages. **Step 5 — Technical and on-page fixes** from the SEMrush Site Audit, prioritised by impact. **Step 6 — Off-page:** industry publication guest posts, original research for digital PR, LinkedIn thought leadership. **Step 7 — Measurement:** SEMrush Position Tracking for rankings and share of voice; GA4 goals and UTM-tagged campaigns for marketing-qualified leads, cost per lead and pipeline influence; monthly review and reallocation.

18. Explain the concept of Search Engine optimization and its significance in digital marketing. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023, Q4a]

Define SEO (§2.10.1), explain the SEO/PPC/SEM distinction, the six-step process, and the three pillars (technical, on-page, off-page). Significance: 53% of all traffic, highest buyer intent, compounding and near-zero marginal cost, greater credibility than ads, competitive defence, and measurable results.

19. Describe the role of content in SEO. How can business create high quality SEO friendly content? [SEE Oct/Nov 2023, Q4b]

Role: content is king — search engines store and rank text, so high-volume, high-quality relevant content both gives users a reason to stay and return, and gives engines the material from which rankings are computed. It is also the asset that earns backlinks and satisfies E-E-A-T. **How:** research keywords and intent first; write for the reader and optimise afterwards; use the anatomy of a top-ranking page (§2.13.1); maintain 3–5% keyword density with semantic variants; write unique title tags and meta descriptions; structure with one H1 and logical H2/H3s; add rich media for dwell time; link internally with descriptive anchors; keep content fresh through historical audits; and ensure it is more comprehensive and more readable than what currently ranks.

20. Enumerate briefly on the best practices for creating compelling and shareable content on social media platforms to increase brand visibility and engagement. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023, Q3b]

Apply the 7-point quality gate (Unit I §1.9.5); lead with visuals (40× more shareable; 94% more views with relevant images; video gets 135% greater organic reach); follow the 4-1-1 rule; write natively for each platform rather than cross-posting; hook within the first three seconds; use 1–2 hashtags only; post consistently at audience-active times; invite participation through polls, questions and contests; scale one master asset with the 4 Rs; and amplify through communities, employees and influencers.

HOW UNIT II IS EXAMINED

In the SEE, Unit II is **Questions 3 and 4 with internal choice** (16 marks, in two 8-mark sub-divisions), plus 2–3 Part-A objective questions. CIE-II is typically dominated by this unit. The highest-probability 10-mark topics are: **the Facebook Algorithm Filter** (asked twice in one paper), **the Content Lifecycle Matrix**, **the 4 Rs of Content Scaling**, **the Customer Lifecycle Orbit with its statistics**, **on-site vs off-site SEO**, and **the SEO audit process**. Note that the SEE also mixes SMM and SEO into applied “design a plan for X” questions — always answer those with a named framework, not free-form opinion.